the subject of another book by Richard Fletcher, *The Cross and the Crescent: Christianity and Islam from Muhammad to the Reformation* (Penguin, 2003).

Paula Sutter Fichtner complements a historical account of the Austrian Empire with social and cultural comments in *The Habsburg Monarchy, 1490 –1848* (Palgrave Macmillan, 2003). The emergence of Germany is described in Harold James, *A German Identity* (London, 2000). Friedrich Naumann's *Central Europe* (New York, 1917) is now of great historic curiosity only. The post-World War I years are brilliantly described in Margaret MacMillan's highly readable *Peacemakers: The Paris Conference of 1919 and Its Attempt to End War* (London, 2001), which is of great help in understanding why Europe went to war once again in 1939. A similarly excellent account of the civilisation of the entire continent is Eric von Kuehnelt-Leddihn's *The Intelligent American's Guide to Europe* (Arlington House, 1979), also a must-read for every intelligent European trying to understand European history, even nearly 50 years after its publication. It is probably the best book I have ever read about European civilisation. More conventional, but still very readable, is JM Roberts's *History of Europe* (Penguin, 1997).

My main source for the general history of Central Europe (although limited to the history of the Czech lands, Slovakia, Poland and Hungary) was Piotr S Wandycz, *The Price of Freedom, A History of East Central Europe from the Middle Ages to the Present* (Routledge, 2001). *The Palgrave Concise Historical Atlas of Eastern Europe* (Palgrave, 2001) by Dennis P Hupchick and Harold E Cox was an excellent companion. Adrian Hyde-Price's *The International Politics of East Central Europe* (Manchester University Press, 1996) has a very valuable overview of bilateral relations in the region. Most of the economic data and observations in this book are based on *The Origins of Backwardness in Eastern Europe* (University of California Press, 1991) by Daniel Chirot (ed.), and Angus Maddison's *The World Economy: Historical Statistics* (OECD 2003). The latter presents the backbone of the economic arguments in my book, while the social and cultural aspects are in great part based on *Inventing Eastern Europe* (Stanford University Press, 1994) by Larry Wolff, which is a detailed study of the emergence of the concept of Eastern Europe, also with examples from literature.